



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: San Marcos Academy
School Website: <https://www.smabears.org/>

December 22, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

San Marcos Academy (SMA) presents a hybrid of Christian formation and classical elements, anchored by a robust religious/philosophical framework and a clearly articulated mission to form virtue, character, and leadership. The school actively frames itself as a Christ-centered educational community with a transformational Christian pedagogy (TfT) and a continuous emphasis on character, integrity, service, and lifelong learning. This strong religious-metaphysical orientation aligns well with Element 1 and Element 2 criteria, and the explicit articulation of mission/vision and "Transformational Christian Education" provides substantive evidence for a classical orientation in those domains.

However, SMA's public materials emphasize Christian formation, disciplinary community, and TfT rather than explicit classical curriculum primitives such as the liberal arts triad (grammar, logic, rhetoric), explicit Great Books/Great Conversation programming, or the full spectrum of Socratic pedagogy in upper grades. In Curriculum (Element 3) and Pedagogy (Element 4), SMA demonstrates many classical tendencies (formation of wonder, memory work in lower grades, and seminar-like discussion in some settings through TfT), but the explicit, widely-recognized classical markers (e.g., grammar-logic-rhetoric curriculum, universal Great Books study, broad use of Socratic seminars in high school) are not consistently evident in the material available. Consequently, the aggregate assessment lands in SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.

Key insights: - Religious foundations and communal practices are central (Christ-centered, worship/discipleship) and strongly supported by mission/vision language and TfT alignment, which anchors Element 1 and Element 2 as CLASSICAL. - Curriculum and pedagogy show substantial classical flavor (transformational Christian education, deep-rooted Bible curriculum, memory-rich lower-school practices) but lack explicit, public-facing Great Books integration and explicit liberal-arts sequencing (grammar-logic-rhetoric) in the available materials, which tempers Element 3 and Element 4 toward SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL. - Faculty portrayals emphasize virtue-driven teaching and mentorship, supporting Element 5 as CLASSICAL. - Parent/community engagement exists (parent testimonials, admissions communications, and community events), but explicit "co-teaching with parents" or formal parent-education programs are not clearly evidenced in the public materials, nudging Element 6 toward SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.

Overall classification: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.

What would move the needle toward CLASSICAL (Element-by-Element focus): - Make explicit the liberal-arts framework (grammar, logic, rhetoric) across grades, with published scope-and-sequence and a public-facing Great Books/Great Conversation component. - Integrate regular, documented Socratic seminars or seminars-based upper-school humanities that foreground dialectic and rhetoric. - Publicly articulate a programmatic emphasis on Great Books, classical history through a "Great Conversation" lens, and a more explicit formation-focused curriculum (formation of mind and virtue as a through-line across disciplines). - Strengthen and publicize a more formal teacher profile and a "living curriculum" framing, including faculty development around classical-methodology and a public articulation of the teacher-student aspirational portraits.

Abstract: SMA displays CLASSICAL leanings in Religious & Metaphysical Foundations and in its formation-focused mission and faculty portrayal, with strong evidence of a transformational Christian pedagogy. How-

ever, explicit classical curricular artifacts (Great Books, grammar-logic-rhetoric sequencing) and explicit Socratic/seminar-based pedagogy at upper levels are not consistently documented in the public materials, placing SMA in SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL overall.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence - SMA positions itself as a Christ-centered, Christian academy with a transformational Christian education model (TfT). This is repeatedly described in public materials as a faith-centered framework guiding the curriculum and student formation. - Mission and vision statements emphasize virtue, integrity, moral formation, and service, with explicit theological grounding (Jesus Christ, Christian values). - Core values and admissions materials foreground belief in Christ and a life oriented toward spiritual and moral aims, including disciplines like service and worship concepts.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: Christ-centered, Christian values, worship, discipleship, truth, justice, service, integrity, virtue, moral compass, integrity, lifelong learning, leadership as a fruit of faith, community. These map to the Positive Keywords list (truth, goodness, beauty; virtue; moral formation; worship; great conversation; etc.).

- Negative keywords present: None evident in the public materials; the focus remains overtly positive and faith-centered. The absence of secular-religion tension or competing metaphysical frameworks supports a CLASSICAL designation here.

Why this rating - The materials explicitly articulate a theological and liturgical orientation (grounded in Christian faith, worship/discipleship) and a theologically informed moral formation program, aligning with the transcendental moral realism and grounded theology expectations of Element 1. The explicit emphasis on virtues, integrity, and community further reinforces a classical foundation here.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The public materials emphasize formation of virtue and character over job preparation; the mission describes leaders formed with integrity, moral compass, service, and lifelong learning. - Vision explicitly frames long-form human excellence, lifelong learning, and service as central aims, not primarily career training. - The extra emphasis on character-building and a culture of “Christ-centered, service-oriented” leadership aligns with virtue/formative aims described in classical rubrics.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: virtue, character, integrity, moral compass, lifelong learning, service, formation, leadership, human flourishing, spiritual depth. These are core positive indicators in the Six Elements lexicon. - Negative keywords present: None obvious in SMA’s public materials (no overt emphasis on vocational/workforce-readiness alone as the primary goal). The materials foreground formation and virtue.

Why this rating - The school’s stated goals center on formation, virtue, wisdom, and leadership grounded in Christian values, which aligns with classical ideals of truth, beauty, and goodness expressed as real and knowable in a teleological sense. This supports CLASSICAL in Element 2.

Element 3: School Curriculum — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - Curriculum is framed around TfT (Teaching for Transformation) with a Deep Roots Bible curriculum in PreK, and a vertically aligned program from PreK through 12, including an emphasis on discipleship concepts (worship, truth, justice, service, community). This shows a formation- and narrative-centered approach rather than a strict liberal-arts sequence. - Public materials emphasize Biblical/Christian content and TfT rather than canonical liberal-arts pillars (grammar, logic, rhetoric) or Great Books, which would be expected in a strong classical curriculum. - Foundational statements describe “Transformational Christian

Education” and “Vertical Alignment,” suggesting a coherent but theology-centric curriculum rather than a full classical curriculum as defined by liberal arts curricula.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: Great Books, Great Conversation (mentioned in the Six Elements doc as a classical aspiration) is not publicly evident; instead, the site highlights “Great Conversation” as a concept in the knowledge base, but SMA’s site emphasizes TtT and Bible-based content rather than canonical Great Books. The Positive Keywords list includes “great conversation” as a positive indicator; its explicit presence in SMA’s public materials is not demonstrated, which signals a gap relative to classical canonical practice. The Deep Roots Bible curriculum and TtT model are present; “transformation” and “discipleship” are prominent. See evidence of TtT and Deep Roots content. - Negative keywords present: Absence of explicit Great Books/Great Conversation programming in SMA’s public-facing materials; lack of explicit grammar-logic-rhetoric sequencing in the curriculum materials; historical interpretation framed through a Christian TtT lens rather than a classical liberal-arts lens. These absences align with the Negative Keywords list in the Six Elements lexicon.

Why this rating - While SMA demonstrates a strong formation-based curriculum with a coherent progression and a spiritually infused approach, the absence (in public materials) of explicit Great Books/Great Conversation study and explicit grammar-logic-rhetoric sequencing keeps Element 3 from being fully CLASSICAL. The presence of TtT and Bible-centered curriculum places SMA in SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL for Curriculum.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - Lower-school pedagogy includes singing, memory work, and wonder-based memory routines (as described in materials about the Lower/PreK programs and the academy’s memory-oriented practice across grades). This resonates with the contemplative/restful aspects of education noted in the classical rubric. - Upper-school pedagogy includes leadership opportunities, Socratic-style discussion is not explicitly documented, but the TtT model emphasizes dialogic learning, discipleship, and inquiry-oriented learning through real-world application. Public materials emphasize seminars, critical thinking, and leadership experiences (e.g., Student Council, NHS/NJHS, Corp of Cadets). - The explicit traditional classical pedagogy markers (explicit Socratic seminars, formal rhetoric training, defined Great Books discussions) are not consistently documented in SMA’s public materials.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: contemplative/restful learning, memory-deepening activities (singing/memory in lower grades), Socratic discussion in upper grades is not clearly evidenced but TtT implies dialogic pedagogy; rhetoric training is not publicly documented but leadership and public-facing activities exist (e.g., cadets, student government, etc.). The “singing” and memory emphasis maps to the Positive Keywords related to contemplative, memory-formation aspects. - Negative keywords present: Lack of explicit, public-facing Socratic seminars, explicit rhetoric instruction, and Great Books-oriented pedagogy; absence of detailed, publicly posted grammar-logic-rhetoric pedagogy sequence. This aligns with Negative Keywords in the Six Elements lexicon.

Why this rating - SMA demonstrates a strong formation- and dialogic-leaning pedagogy via TtT and leadership experiences, plus lower-school memory/chanting-like practices, which are classical in spirit but not fully aligned with the canonical classical pedagogy expectations (Socratic seminars, explicit rhetoric training, Great Books discussion). The combination justifies SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL for Pedagogy.

Element 5: Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public materials describe faculty as “passionate, invested” and as “the living curriculum” in effect, with teachers modeling virtue, character, and intellectual capabilities. This aligns well with classical expectations of faculty as mentors and exemplars. - The faculty-student relationship is highlighted as central to SMA’s mission, including testimonials from parents and students praising relationships and the character-forming role of faculty. - SMA emphasizes a long-standing tradition and accreditations, indicating a stable, mission-aligned faculty culture focused on Christian formation and high standards.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: “passionate,” “invested teachers,”

“character-building,” “living curriculum,” “mentors,” “virtuous life,” “integrity,” “moral compass,” “discipleship.” These map cleanly to Positive Keywords in the Six Elements lexicon. - Negative keywords present: None evident in the public materials; the faculty portrayal is consistently virtuous and formation-focused.

Why this rating - The public materials strongly present the faculty as models of virtue and knowledge, embodying the “living curriculum” concept and being central to the students’ formation, which aligns with CLASSICAL. This category receives CLASSICAL.

Element 6: Parents & Community — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - SMA emphasizes partnership with families through admissions communications, financial aid, and parent-facing information (Inquire Here, Pathway to SMA, Academy Nights, etc.). Public materials show parent involvement through testimonials and a broad sense of community. - There are explicit parent testimonials praising SMA’s environment and values (from day parents and boarding families). This suggests parental engagement and investment in the school’s formation mission. - SMA publishes mission/vision, governance-like materials, and programmatic plans that invite parental involvement in the school’s narrative and strategic direction (Pathway to the Future, Academy Nights, etc.).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: partnership with families, parental testimonials, admissions/information access for parents, family involvement in philanthropy and events (Academy Nights). These align with Positive Keywords around parental engagement and community partnership. - Negative keywords present: The explicit phrase “parents as co-teachers” or formal parent-education programs are not clearly evidenced in the public materials; scattered references to parent involvement exist, but a formalized co-teacher model or parent-education series is not publicly documented.

Why this rating - The materials show meaningful parent involvement and a welcoming community, with ongoing opportunities for family engagement and involvement in school events. However, the explicit “parents as co-teachers” or structured parent-education programs are not clearly evidenced, which prevents a FULL CLASSICAL rating in this category. Hence SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.

What Would Move the Needle

- Curriculum modernization and explicit liberal-arts articulation:
 - Publish a formal, public-facing map of grammar, logic, and rhetoric (GLR) integration across grades, with visible cross-disciplinary connections to expose students to the liberal-arts sequencing typical of classical education.
 - Publish a public plan for integrating a Great Books framework or a robust Great Conversation component, including book lists, teacher training plans, and assessment rubrics.
- Pedagogy enhancements:
 - Implement and publicly document regular Socratic seminars or seminar-based instruction in upper grades, with teacher professional development focused on Socratic facilitation and rhetoric.
 - Increase explicit rhetoric training (speech, writing, debate) across upper grades, with public examples of student performances and rubrics.
- Theology-based curriculum alignment:
 - Expand history and literature content to explicitly connect universal truths (truth, goodness, beauty) with secular and sacred sources, while maintaining the TtT framework. This would strengthen the alignment with the Positive Keywords around truth and beauty in the Six Elements lexicon.
- Parent/community strategies:
 - Create and publish a formal “Parents as Co-Teachers” program with structured book studies, parent education series, and regular home-school collaboration opportunities.
 - Provide periodic public-facing reports of parent involvement, co-teaching opportunities, and community-engagement outcomes.

Citations and evidence basis - Core evidence for the school's current posture (TfT, Christian formation, mission/vision, and the faithful portrayal of faculty) is drawn from SMA materials describing Transformation Education, Deep Roots biblical curriculum, and mission statements.

- Positive and negative keyword alignment is grounded in the Six Essential Elements lexicon (Positive Keywords and Negative Keywords) and the related categorization anchored in the public-facing SMA content. - Additional supporting materials include All six categories' evidence blocks drawn from SMA pages describing mission, vision, programmatic structure, and faculty/community narratives.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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